Understanding the Design Language of HYUNDAI

NEW THINKING. NEW POSSIBILITIES.

Ayaan Ahmad

The Genesis of a Design Legacy

1947 The parent organization, Hyundai Group, was founded by Chung Ju-yung in post-WWII South Korea.

1967 **Hyundai Motor Company.**
The specific automotive division was established on December 29, 1967.

1968 Hyundai assembled the CORTINA as its very first vehicle with Ford Motor Company. In 1968, CORTINA was successfully assembled in the Ulsan Plant, South Korea, accrediting Hyundai Motor with outstanding manufacturing capacity.

1975 The HYUNDAI PONY was launched as South Korea's first mass-produced, independently developed vehicle. designed by an Italian designer Giogetto Giugiaro

1985 In a period of rapid expansion, the first-generation SONATA was introduced in 1985 and in 1986, the Pony Excel became the first Hyundai model sold in the United States.

1996 Hyundai achieved Global product standardization.
ACCENT & ELANTRA helped Hyundai:
- Establish a consistent global lineup
- Improve fit, finish, and ergonomics

1998 Hyundai Motor Company acquired a 51% stake in the bankrupt Kia Motors during the Asian financial crisis, forming the Hyundai Motor Group.

2008 The groundbreaking GENESIS, embodies Hyundai Motor's vision of an ideal premium sedan that passed rigorous performance tests and thorough quality controls. The car won several American Awards in the year 2009.

2009 **Fluidic Sculpture Design Philosophy**

2013 **Fluidic Sculpture 2.0**
"Fluidic Sculpture is based on the idea that motion exists even when the car is stationary."

2015 CRETA, The Perfect SUV.

2017 i30 N, Hyundai N's first high performance car enters production. This sub-brand is dedicated to creating track-capable, fun-to-drive vehicles inspired by motorsport.

2018 KONA ELECTRIC, with an early EV adoption, featuring a more dynamic road presence, a futuristic look and functional digital interfaces.

2019 **Sensuous Sportiness Design Philosophy**
Sensuous → Emotional value, beauty, desire
Sportiness → Energy, proportion, performance-oriented stance

2021 IONIQ 5 introduced, bringing an EV design revolution with Triple Win in a single year.

2022 IONIQ 6, the facelifted model features more refined curves and enhanced proportions for a sleek and beautifully balanced silhouette.

In 2022, after seven years of envisioning hydrogen-powered high performance, the N VISION 74 sets Hyundai N's sights beyond electric cars.

What Is Design Language in Automotive Context?

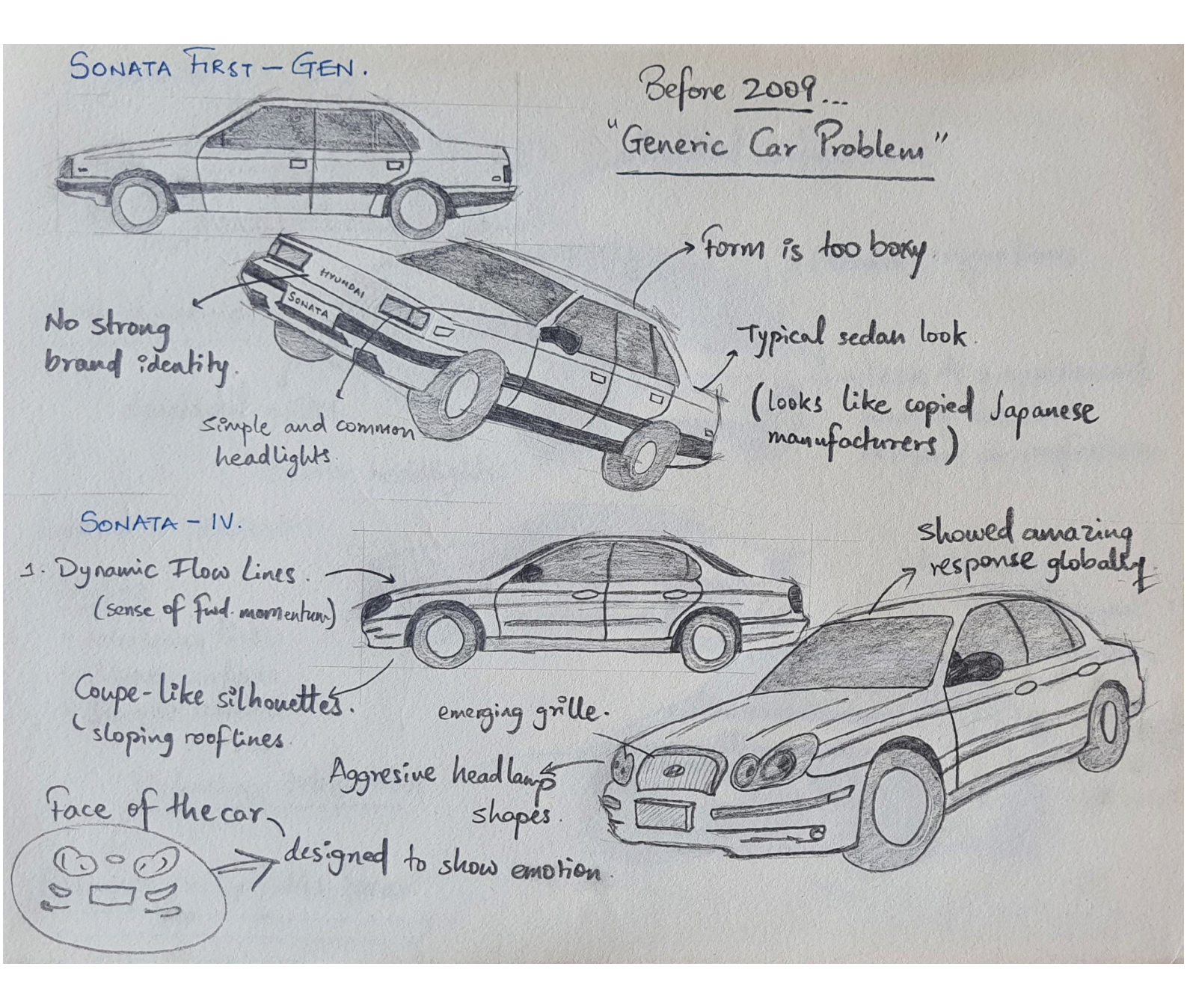
Automotive design language is a complete visual and conceptual strategy that defines how a company's cars look and feel, including everything from proportions to brand identity. It has an impact on the exterior, interior, and how individuals feel emotionally connected to the car.

2009 - Fluidic Sculpture Design Philosophy

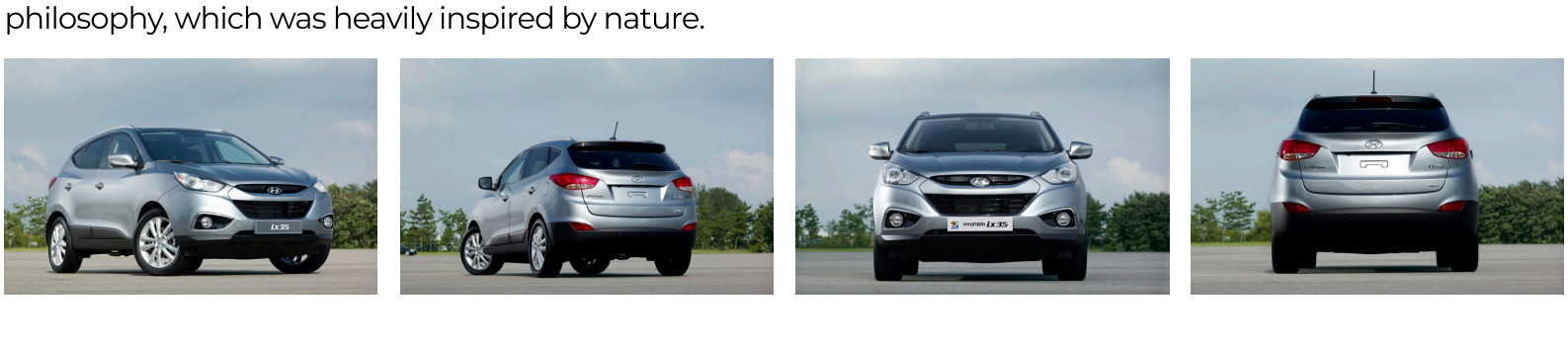
Why Fluidic Sculpture Was Necessary?
Before 2009, Hyundai suffered from a "generic car problem"
- Designs were safe but forgettable
- No strong brand recall
- Looked like copies of Japanese competitors

Comparison between Hyundai Accent and Mitsubishi Cedia in 2009

Design Inspiration
- Natural elements: wind, water flow, waves
- Organic movement rather than mechanical rigidity
- The car as a sculpted object shaped by airflow


SONATA FIRST – GEN.
Before 2009...
"Generic Car Problem"
Form is too boxy
No strong brand identity
Typical sedan look
(looks like copied Japanese manufacturers)
Simple and common headlights
SONATA – IV.
1. Dynamic Flow Lines (sense of fwd. momentum)
showed amazing response globally
Coupe-like silhouettes
sloping rooflines
emerging grille.
Aggresive headlamp shapes.
Face of the car
designed to show emotion.

The **2010 Hyundai Tucson (ix35)** was the first production car to embody Hyundai's "Fluidic Sculpture" design philosophy, which was heavily inspired by nature.



BREAKTHROUGH MODELS SHOWCASING FLUIDIC SCULPTURE (2011-12)

Hyundai Elantra (Avante)

Hyundai Sonata (Hybrid)

Limitations & Criticism
1. Over-Styling
   - Too many lines and creases, visual clutter in some models
2. Aging Poorly
   - Designs looked dated quickly, excessive curves reduced timelessness

2013 - Fluidic Sculpture 2.0 Design Philosophy

Hyundai realized:
- Emotion should be balanced with caution.
- Design should mature as the brand's authority develops.

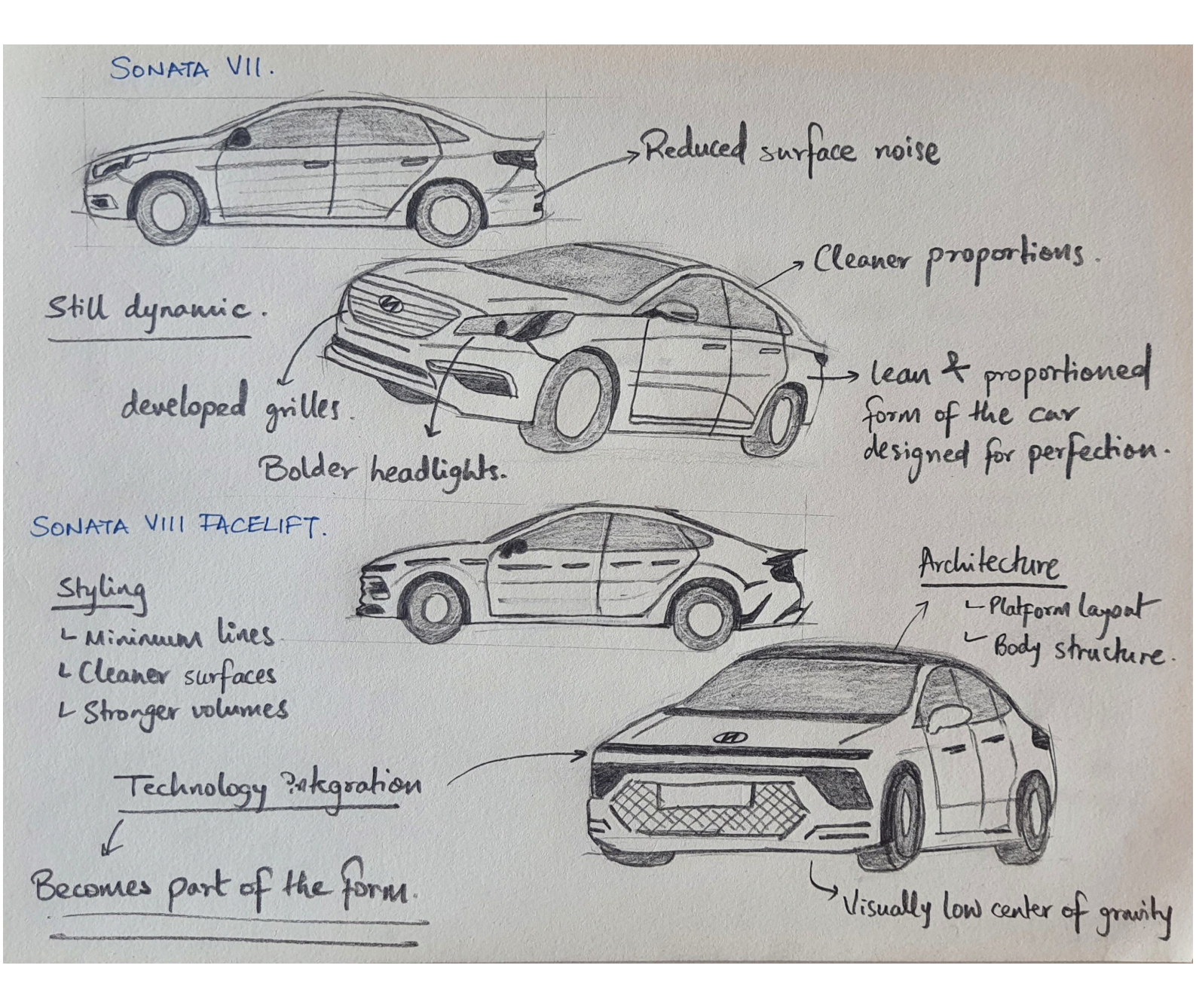
Fluidic Sculpture 2.0 reduced surface noise, cleaner proportions, better harmony between form and function.

The **2014 Hyundai Genesis (second generation)** was the first car to globally adopt the Fluidic Sculpture 2.0 design language.

BREAKTHROUGH MODELS SHOWCASING FLUIDIC SCULPTURE 2.0 (2014-15)

Hyundai Sonata (LF)

Hyundai Tucson (TL)


SONATA VII.
Reduced surface noise
Cleaner proportions.
Still dynamic.
developed grilles.
Bolder headlights.
Lean & proportioned form of the car designed for perfection.
SONATA VIII FACELIFT.
Styling
Minimum lines
Cleaner surfaces
Stronger volumes
Architecture
Platform layout
Body structure
Technology Integration
Becomes part of the form.
Visually low center of gravity

2019 - Sensuous Sportiness Design Philosophy

Fluidic Sculpture had an established identity, but lacked long-term maturity.
EVs, autonomous technology, and digital interfaces required clarity above drama.
Hyundai recognized the need of rational, disciplined and experience-driven design, instead of being expressive.

Hyundai realized that:
Design could no longer be only expressive — it had to be intelligent, structured, and experience-driven.

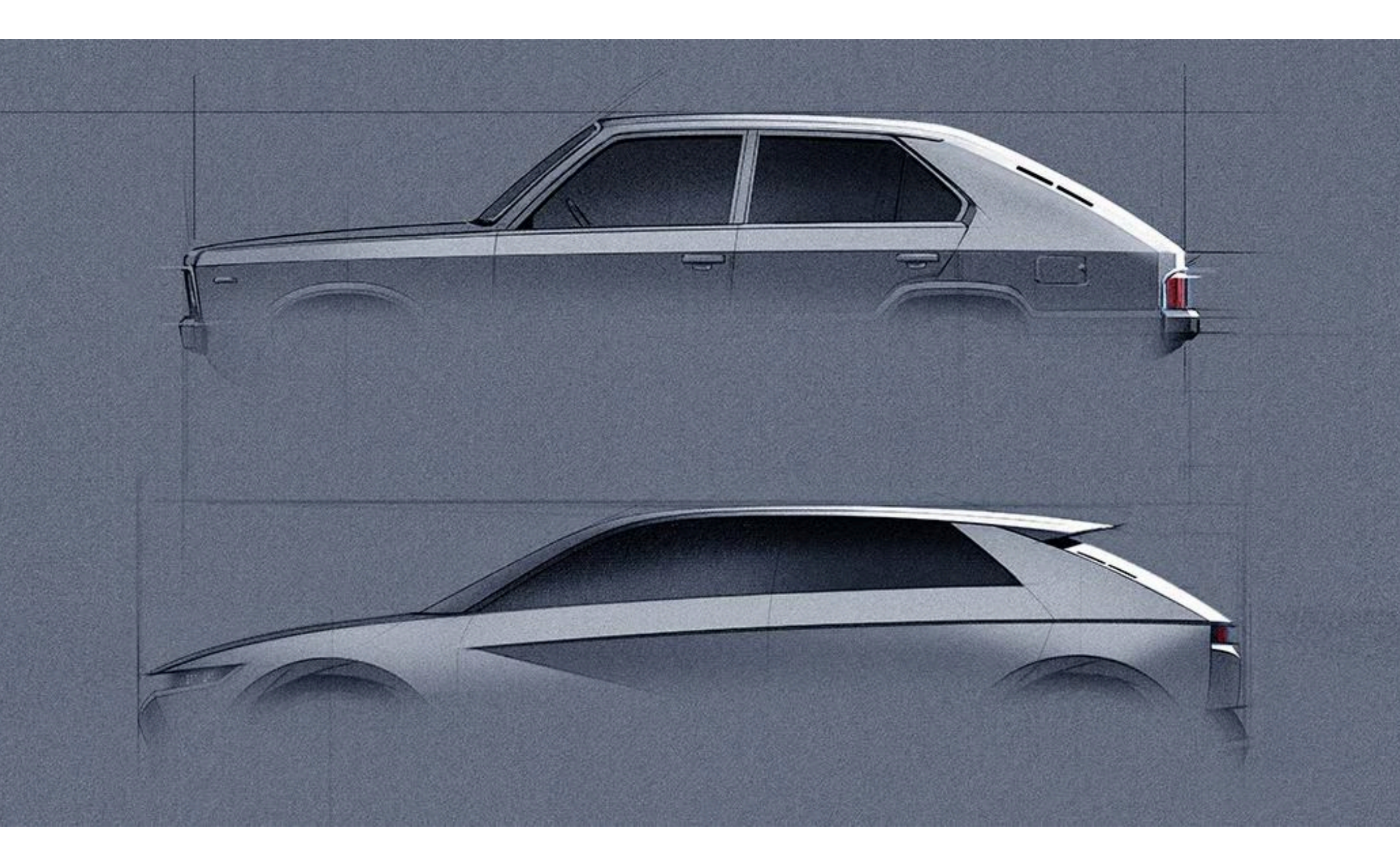
The **Le Fil Rouge (HDC-1) concept car**, unveiled at the 2018 Geneva International Motor Show, was the first Hyundai vehicle to feature the "Sensuous Sportiness" design identity.

Le Fil Rouge.

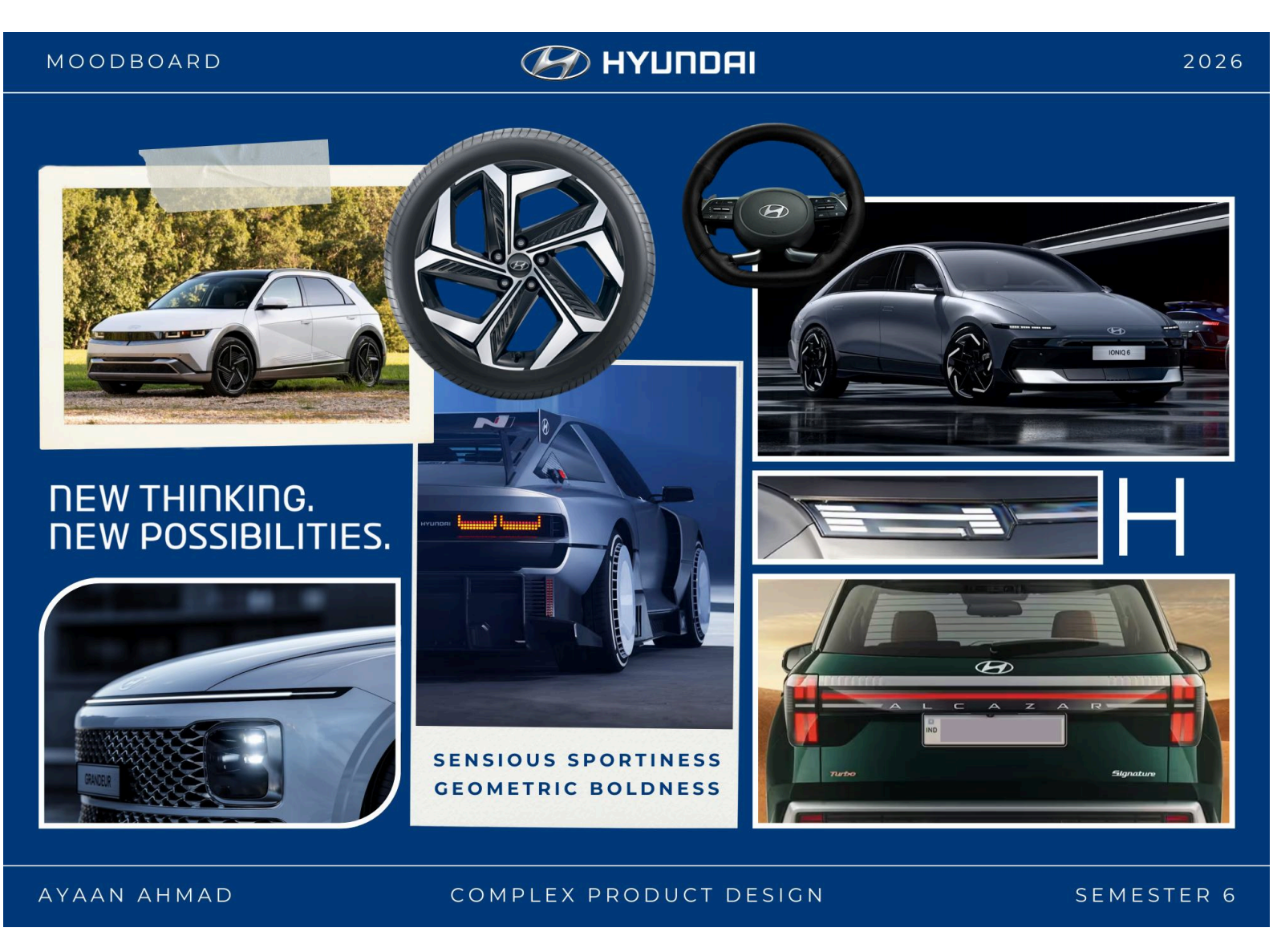
BREAKTHROUGH MODELS SHOWCASING SENSUOUS SPORTINESS (2020-21)

Hyundai IONIQ 5

Hyundai Tucson

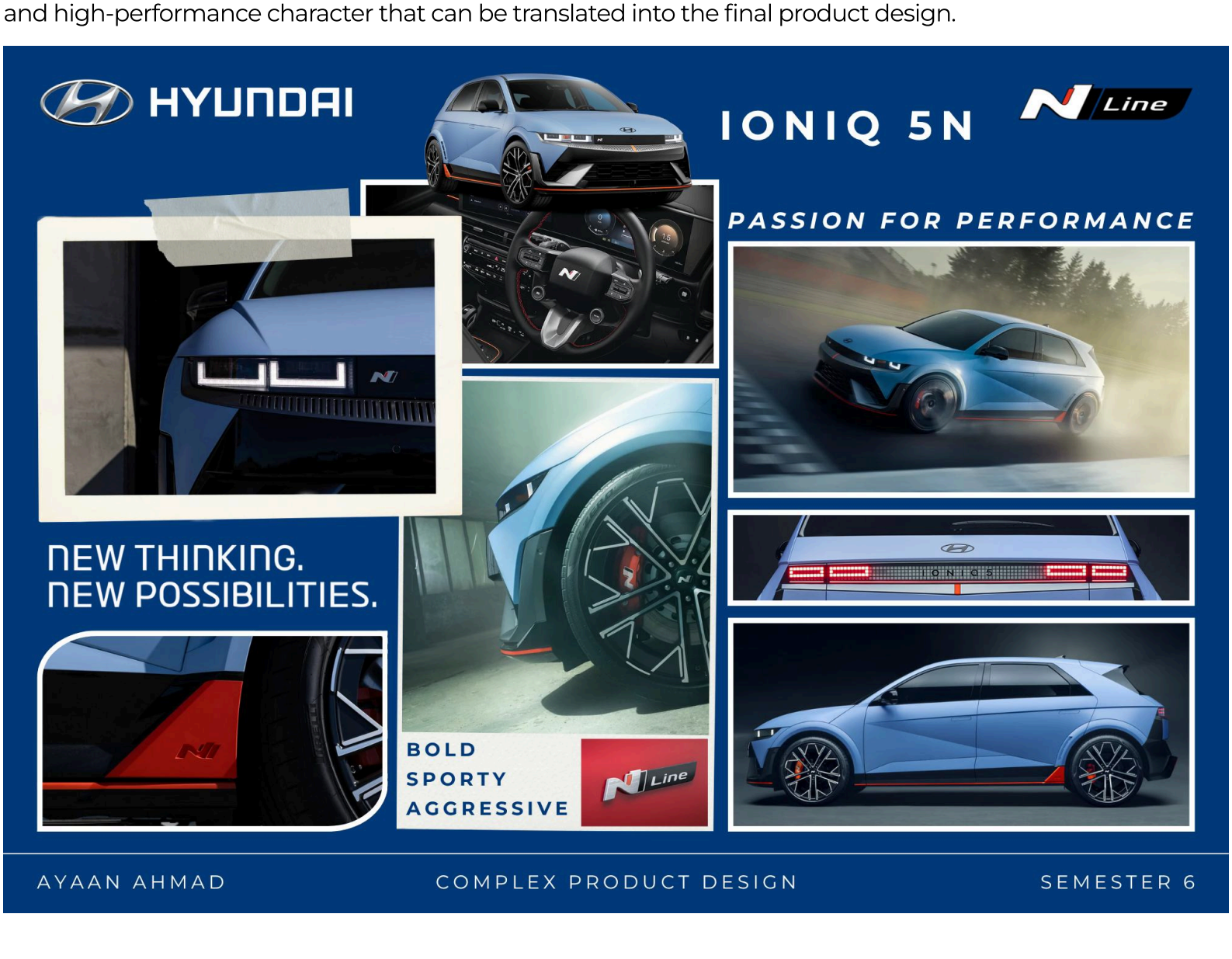


MOODBOARD


MOODBOARD
HYUNDAI
2026
NEW THINKING. NEW POSSIBILITIES.
SENSIOUS SPORTINESS
GEOMETRIC BOLDNESS
AYAAN AHMAD
COMPLEX PRODUCT DESIGN
SEMESTER 6

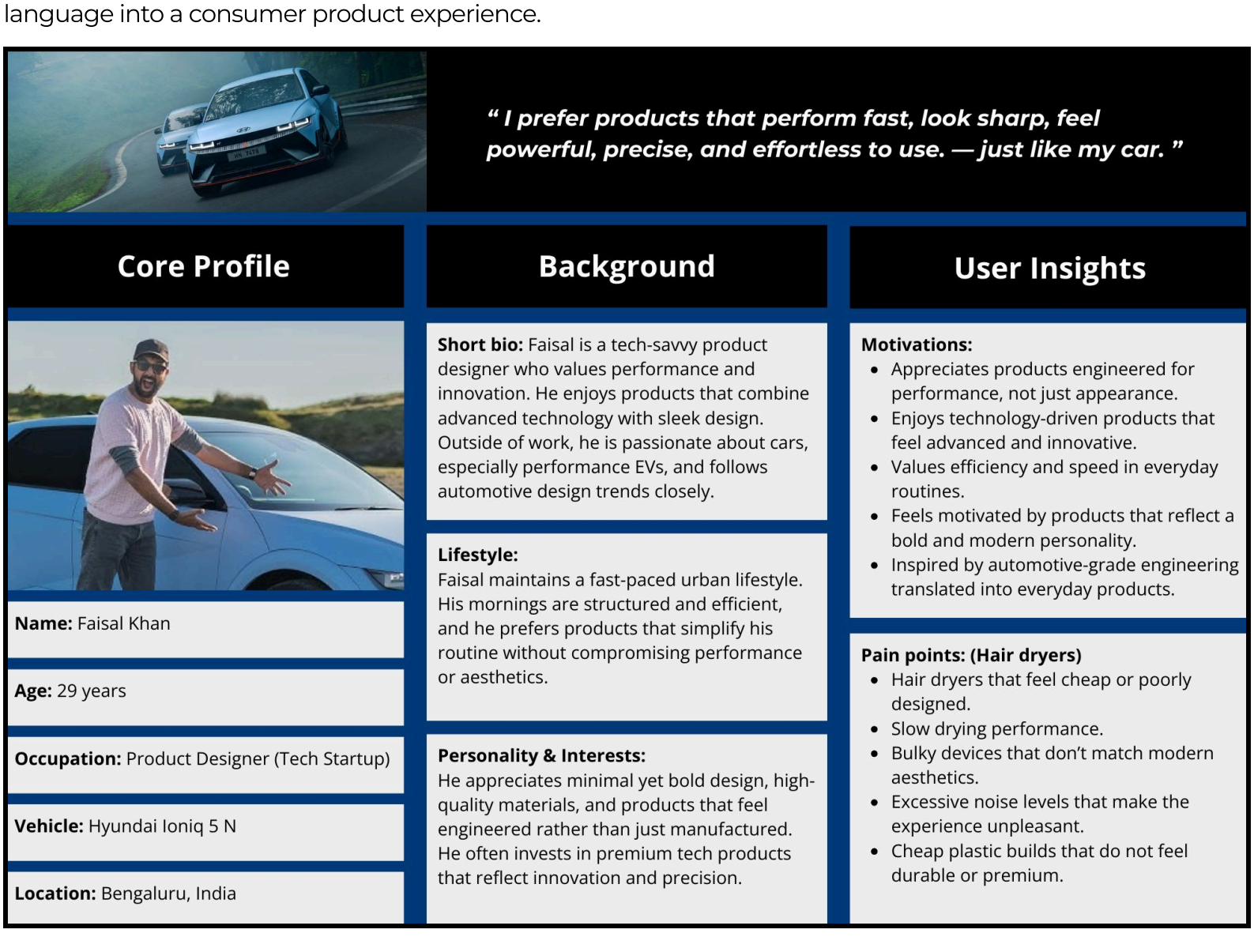
This moodboard represents the overall brand identity of Hyundai, highlighting its current **"Sensuous Sportiness"** design philosophy.

However, applying the entire brand spectrum to the hair dryer concept would be too broad. Therefore, the focus has been narrowed to the **Hyundai Ioniq 5 N**, which reflects a more defined design direction. This model, along with the Hyundai N performance lineup, emphasizes bold aesthetics, technological innovation, and high-performance character that can be translated into the final product design.


HYUNDAI
IONIQ 5N
N Line
PASSION FOR PERFORMANCE
NEW THINKING. NEW POSSIBILITIES.
BOLD
SPORTY
AGGRESSIVE
AYAAN AHMAD
COMPLEX PRODUCT DESIGN
SEMESTER 6

USER PERSONA

Now, a hypothetical user persona is created to represent the values and characteristics associated with the Hyundai performance identity. By understanding the user's background, lifestyle, and preferences, we can analyze their expectations and insights regarding a hair dryer inspired by the design philosophy of the Hyundai Ioniq 5 N. This approach helps translate the brand's performance, technology, and bold design language into a consumer product experience.



" I prefer products that perform fast, look sharp, feel powerful, precise, and effortless to use. — just like my car. "

Core Profile

Name: Faisal Khan

Age: 29 years

Occupation: Product Designer (Tech Startup)

Vehicle: Hyundai Ioniq 5 N

Location: Bengaluru, India

Background

Short bio: Faisal is a tech-savvy product designer who values performance and innovation. He enjoys products that combine advanced technology with sleek design. Outside of work, he is passionate about cars, especially performance EVs, and follows automotive design trends closely.

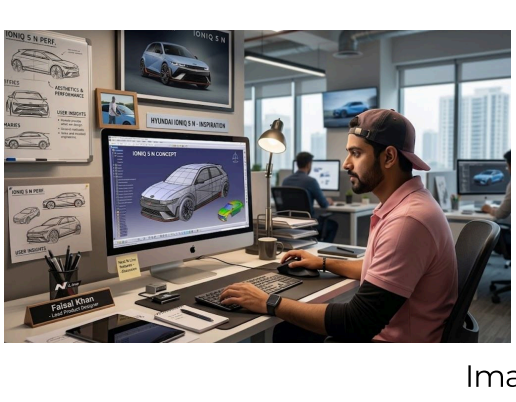
Lifestyle:
Faisal maintains a fast-paced urban lifestyle. His mornings are structured and efficient, and he prefers products that simplify his routine without compromising performance or aesthetics.

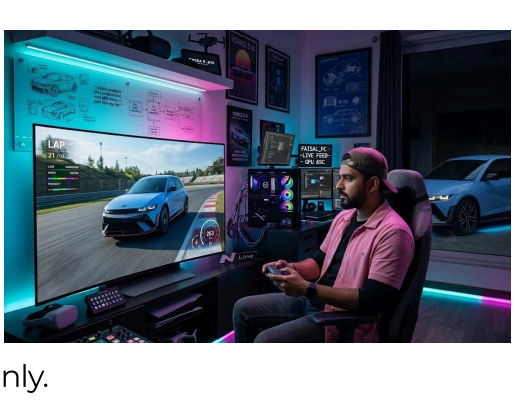
Personality & Interests:
He appreciates minimal yet bold design, high-quality materials, and products that feel engineered rather than just manufactured. He often invests in premium tech products that reflect innovation and precision.

User Insights

Motivations:
- Appreciates products engineered for performance, not just appearance.
- Enjoys technology-driven products that feel advanced and innovative.
- Values efficiency and speed in everyday routines.
- Feels motivated by products that reflect a bold and modern personality.
- Inspired by automotive-grade engineering translated into everyday products.

Pain points: (Hair dryers)
- Hair dryers that feel cheap or poorly designed.
- Slow drying performance.
- Bulky devices that don't match modern aesthetics.
- Excessive noise levels that make the experience unpleasant.
- Cheap plastic builds that do not feel durable or premium.





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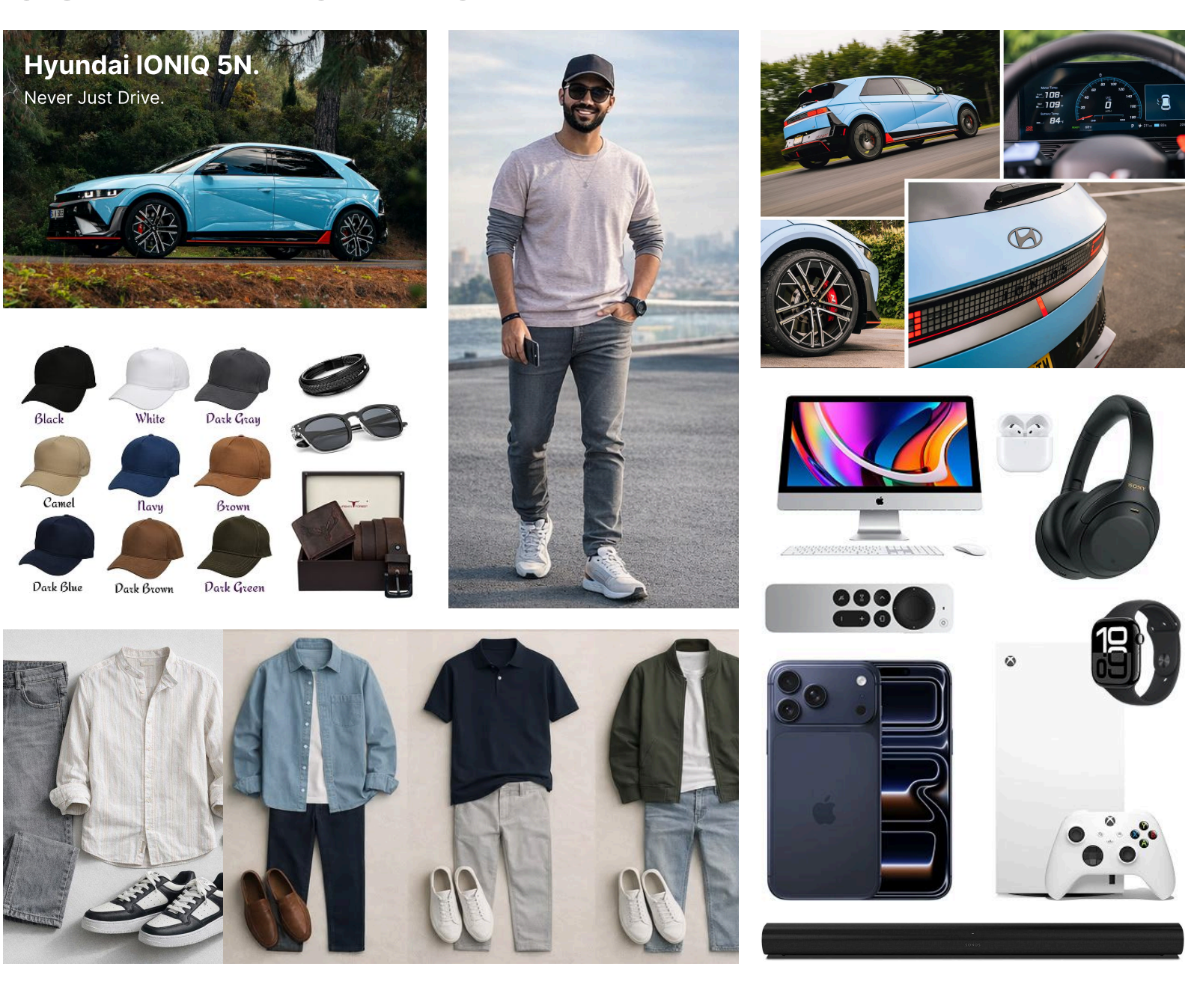
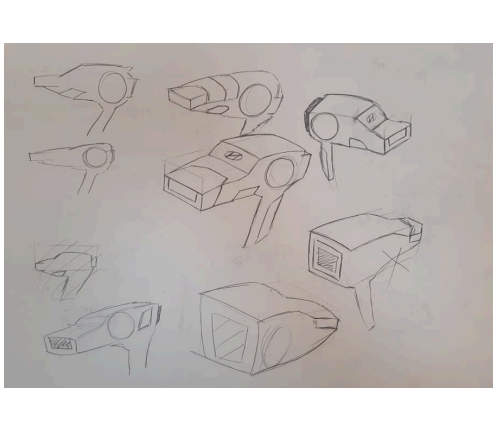
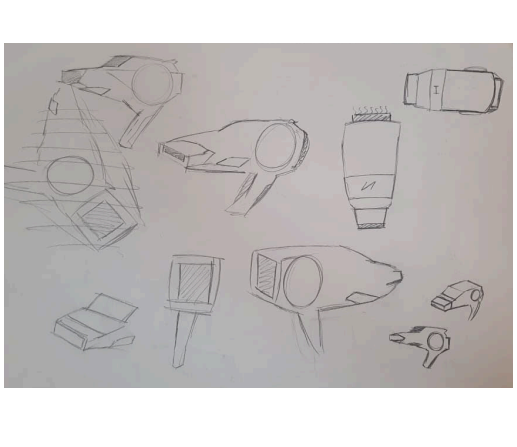
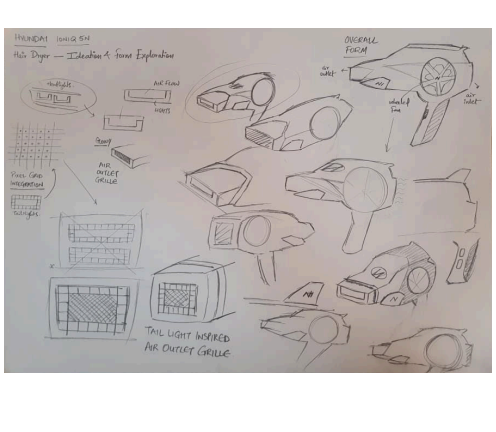
USER IMAGE BOARD - Faisal Khan


Hyundai IONIQ 5N.
Never Just Drive.
Black
White
Dark Gray
Camel
Navy
Brown
Dark Blue
Dark Brown
Dark Green

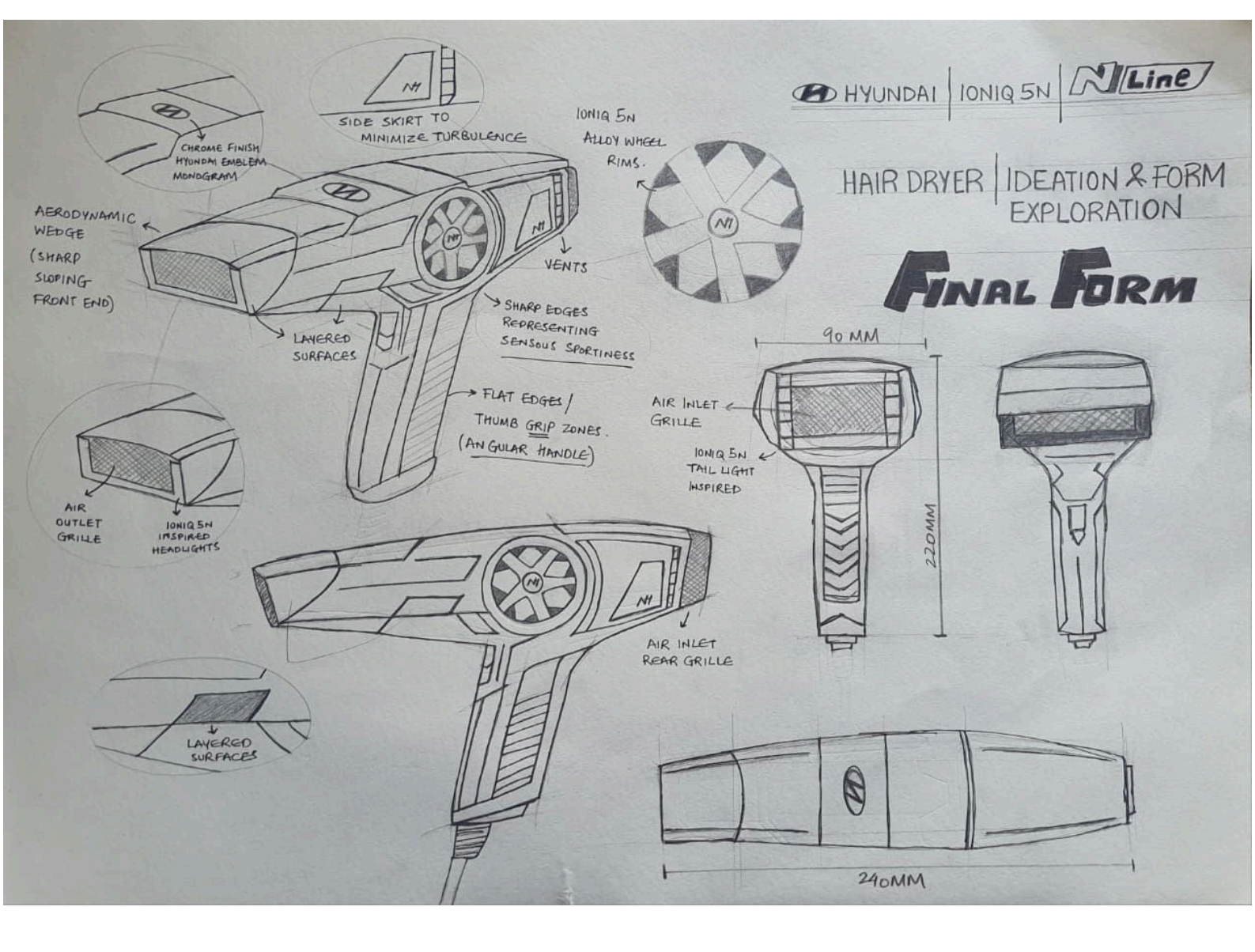
Ideation Sketches & Form Exploration



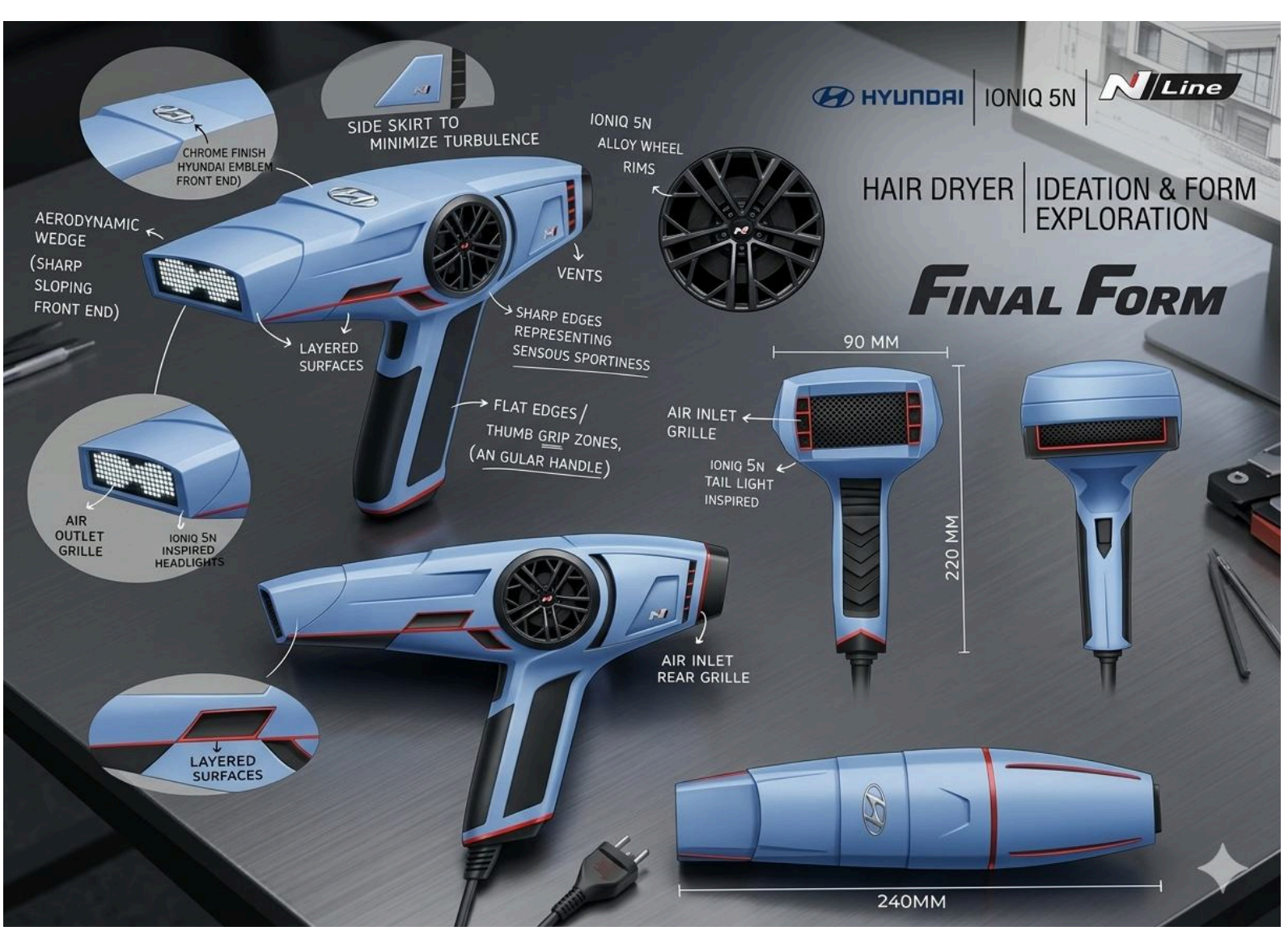




Final Concept


HYUNDAI
IONIQ 5N
N Line
HAIR DRYER
IDEATION & FORM EXPLORATION
FINAL FORM
SIDE SKIRT TO MINIMIZE TURBULENCE
CHROME FINISH HYUNDAI EMBLEM MONOGRAM
IONIQ 5N ALLOY WHEEL RIMS.
AERODYNAMIC WEDGE (SHARP SLOPING FRONT END)
VENTS
LAYERED SURFACES
SHARP EDGES REPRESENTING SENSOUS SPORTINESS
FLAT EDGES / THUMB GRIP ZONES. (ANGULAR HANDLE)
AIR OUTLET GRILLE
IONIQ 5N INSPIRED HEADLIGHTS
AIR INLET GRILLE
IONIQ 5N TAIL LIGHT INSPIRED
90 MM
220MM
AIR INLET REAR GRILLE
LAYERED SURFACES
240MM

Rendered Concept


HYUNDAI
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90 MM
220 MM
AIR INLET REAR GRILLE
LAYERED SURFACES
240MM

Image is for representation purpose only. (AI Generated by Gemini)

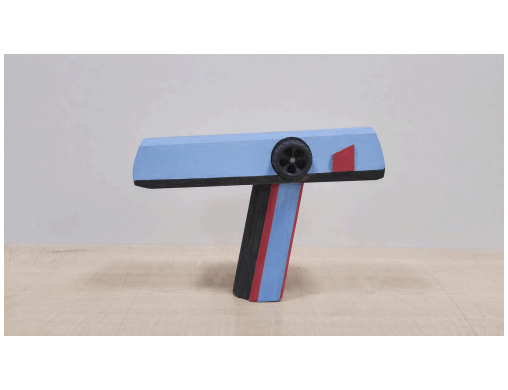
Transforming into Reality

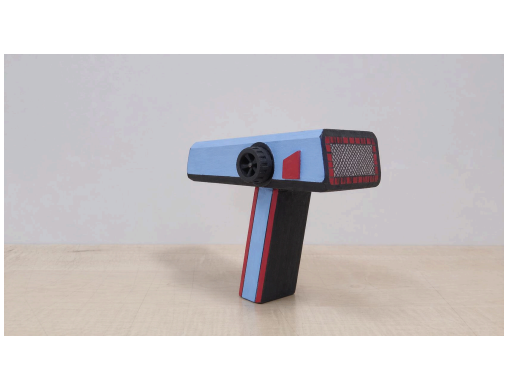
Exploring the study forms in 2D and 3D using cardboard and paper, to understand the product in reality.

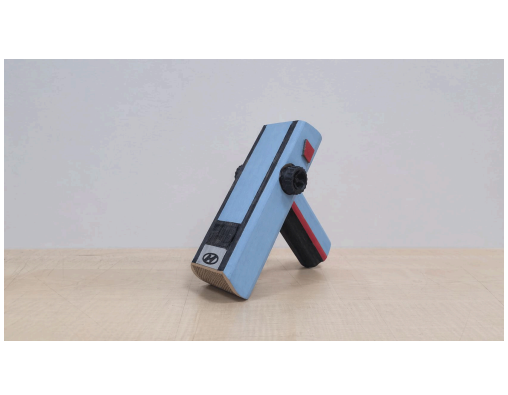
Now that I had prior experience working with materials like cardboard, paper sheets, and PU sheets in product design, I decided to explore a new material for this product—wood. After visiting the workshop and gaining a hands-on understanding of various wood types, I selected MDF as the most suitable material. I then began developing my product, using my final concept as the primary reference.

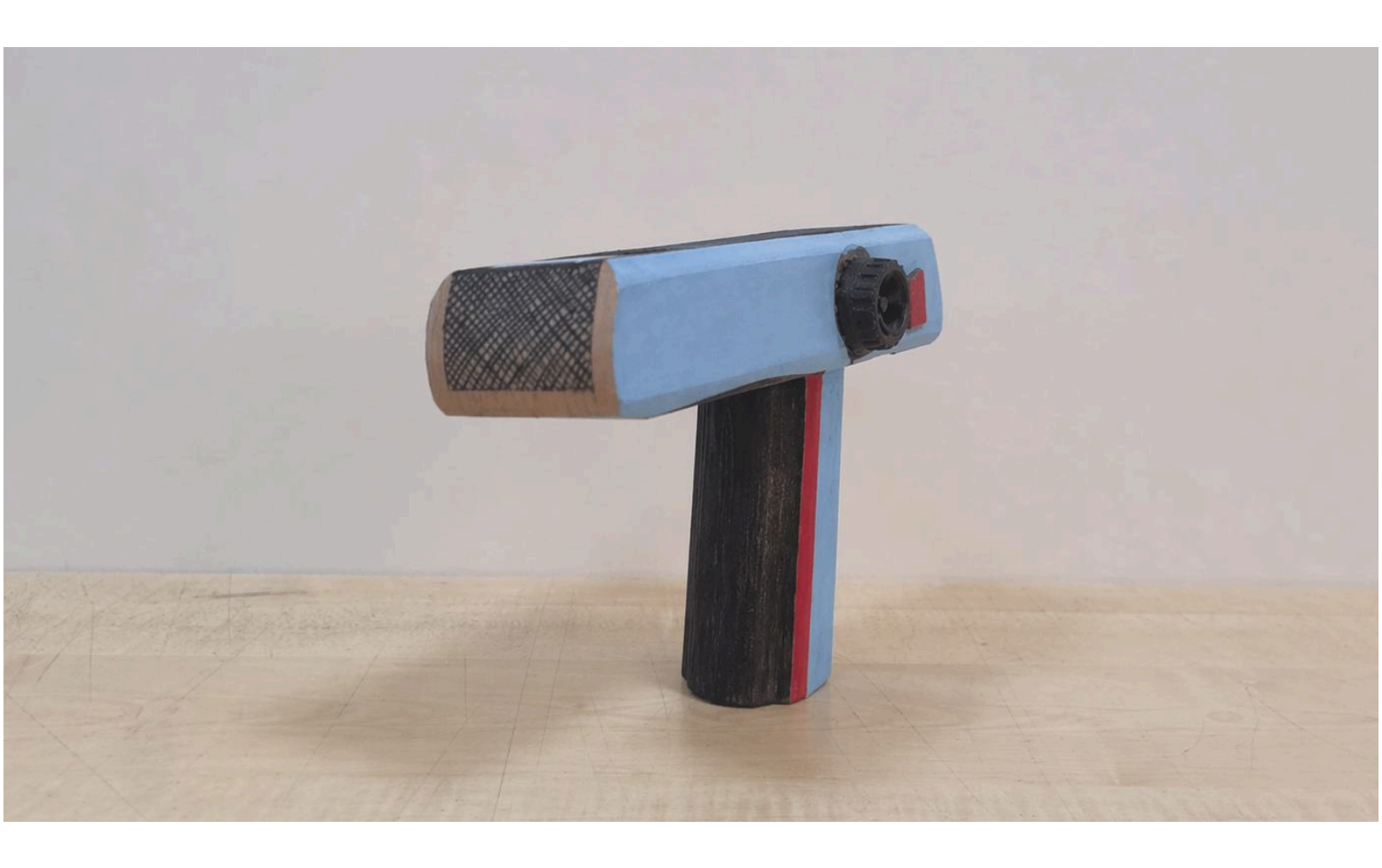
It took me approximately 7 hours to reach this stage of the product. The process involved a lot of trial and error—layering and sticking multiple MDF sheets to achieve the required thickness for the body and handle, followed by careful filing to create a smooth finish.
Additionally, I was able to source real toy car wheels, which I attached on both sides to enhance the overall realism of the design.

I then colored the product to reflect the Hyundai IONIQ 5 N Line, adding a red side skirt, headlights, pixel-style tail lights, and red accent lines to capture its identity.









Hyundai IONIQ 5 N.

Ayaan Ahmad.